

Among the many notable musicians who were drawn to Rome in the 17th century, Arcangelo Corelli was famed for his expressive violin-playing and exemplary compositions. Although he was by all accounts a serene and modest man, his performances were said often to be fiery and dynamic.

Arcangelo was born in Fusignano in February 1653 into a family of wealthy landowners. His father died just before he was born, so he and his four siblings were raised solely by their mother. He probably received his first music lessons from a priest and, in 1666, aged 13, was sent to Bologna to continue his studies. An exceptional violin-player, he was soon accepted as a member of Bologna's recently founded Accademia Filarmonica.

From strength to strength

Corelli flourished after moving to Rome in the mid-1670s. Propelled by impressive family connections and considerable talent, he moved up the ranks of instrumentalists to become a chamber musician to the former queen of Sweden, Christina, who had lived in the city since her abdication in 1654. He dedicated his Op. 1 collection of church sonatas to her and, while working for other members of Rome's elite, continued to perform for her until her death in 1689.

Cardinal Benedetto Pamphili, a great patron of the arts and a competent composer himself, lured Corelli to play in the Sunday concerts at his palace in Rome, and later appointed him as his music master. "Il Bolognese," as Corelli was known, also attracted the patronage of Cardinal Pietro Ottoboni, to whom he dedicated his Op. 4 collection of chamber trios. The young